He thought Chatar was a mad elephant, yet capable of dismantling the enemy's network. On Christmas evening in 1988, Mathur and Sartaj were ready to bring Chatar in, despite predictions from senior R&AW operatives that this would be a disaster. When they arrived at Chatar's home, Mathur noticed an expression of peace on his recruit's face.

'What followed was like a question and answer session. As Chatar answered each question, he looked anxious but satisfied. He rose from his chair a couple of times during our conversation and strolled around the room, sometimes glancing towards the windows. Sartaj was writing notes in a black diary. An hour later, Chatar took a deep breath, looked at me and asked, is it enough? I nodded and told him we would meet again in the new year,' Mathur recalled.

Chatar had given him a goldmine. He had provided details of Khalistan cadres in Amritsar and Ferozpur, areas of Punjab that saw more terror activities than anywhere else in the state. Mathur's intelligence report with its precise locations of hideouts and identities of modules was exceptional and powerful enough to change the course of the antiinsurgency operation. The report troubled the security establishment in India. At a toplevel meeting at the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) sometime in January, it was decided to carry out a massive security operation in the villages of these districts. It took another month to bring together special commandos of the Central Reserve Police Force, Border Security Force and Punjab police to mount the operation. In the meantime, Mathur and Sartaj pulled together streams of intelligence reports about hotspots in the two districts and inputs about the cadres receiving arms and explosives from across the border with the help of the ISI. The Special Forces offensive began sometime in